Microsoft

FOR US STATE & LOCAL GOVERNMENT · GOVERNMENT COMMUNITY CLOUD (GCC)

Copilot Studio vs. Microsoft Foundry

A high-level guide to choosing the right platform for building AI agents and solutions for GCC customers — and why it's often both.

Bottom line These platforms are **complementary, not competing**. Reach for **Copilot Studio** to build agents fast with low-code and extend Microsoft 365; reach for **Microsoft Foundry** to build custom, developer-led AI on your choice of models. Many government solutions use both together.

Two platforms, different strengths

Microsoft Copilot Studio

Low-code · SaaS

- **Build fast** — design, test, and publish conversational and task agents with a visual canvas and natural language.
- **Extends Microsoft 365** — surface agents in Copilot, Teams, SharePoint, and the web.
- **Connected** — 1,000+ prebuilt connectors and Power Platform integration reach into business systems.
- **Governed** — managed through the Power Platform admin center with DLP and managed environments.
- **Maker-friendly** — fast time-to-value for business teams and IT.

Microsoft Foundry

Pro-code · PaaS

- **Full control** — a unified Azure platform to build custom AI apps and agents, code-first.
- **Model choice** — pick from a broad catalog of models (including Azure OpenAI) with fine-tuning and evaluations.
- **Advanced orchestration** — multi-agent workflows via SDKs and a large tool catalog.
- **Enterprise-ready** — built-in tracing, observability, and responsible-AI guardrails.
- **Scales & publishes** — managed runtime; publish agents to Microsoft 365, Teams, or your own apps.

Lean toward Copilot Studio when...

- You want speed and low-code, maker- or business-led delivery.
- The need is a conversational or task agent — citizen self-service, employee help desk, FAQ.
- You're extending Microsoft 365 Copilot, Teams, or SharePoint.
- You want prebuilt connectors into existing business systems.

Lean toward Microsoft Foundry when...

- You need a custom, code-first AI application or agent.
- You want to select or fine-tune specific models for the use case.
- You need advanced orchestration, custom tools, and deep Azure integration.
- Developers or data scientists own the AI logic and lifecycle.

For GCC customers

Start with the cloud boundary approved for the workload. Copilot Studio has US Government (GCC) offerings; Microsoft Foundry is an Azure platform that may be used in Azure Commercial or Azure Government depending on the agency's tenant, compliance needs, and architecture.

Copilot Studio GCC

Microsoft documents US data residency, physical separation from non-US-Government plans, screened personnel access, and FedRAMP High

Azure choice

GCC customers may use Azure Commercial for related workloads. If a workload requires Azure Government, Foundry is available there in US Gov

Security & governance

Use the controls for the selected platform and cloud boundary: Power Platform DLP and managed environments, Azure RBAC, private